PEARSON EDEXCEL INTERNATIONAL GCSE (9–1) · ENGLISH LANGUAGE B · 4EB1/01

A* Examination Guide

Built from 17 past papers and 16 mark schemes, January 2019 to June 2026

This guide is built from the 4EB1 question papers and mark schemes. The level descriptors, indicative content and examiner notes show exactly what earns marks: the same assessment objectives, the same five levels and the same question types appear on every paper. Learn the method for each question, then practise it under time.

1 How Paper 1 is built
2 What the levels reward
3 Twenty rules from the mark schemes
4 Short-answer questions (Q1, 2, 4, 5)
5 Language analysis (Q3, Q6) and comparison (Q7)
6 Section B: directed writing (Q8)
7 Section C: argument, story, description
8 AO5: technical accuracy
9 Timing plan and final checklist

Papers analysed: Jan 2019 (4EB1 and legacy 4EB0), Jun 2019, Jan 2020, Nov 2020, Jun 2021, Nov 2021, Jan 2022, Jun 2022, Jan 2023, Jun 2023, Nov 2023, Jun 2024, Nov 2024, Jun 2025, Nov 2025, Jun 2026. Papers are cited by series, e.g. (Jun 25).

1 How Paper 1 is built

Format: 3 hours, 100 marks, three sections of one hour each. Two linked passages (Text One and Text Two) on the same theme are printed in a Source Booklet. Dictionaries are not allowed. Plans are not marked unless nothing else is written.

Q	Task	Marks	AO	Time
1, 2	retrieve one point from given lines of Text One	1 + 1	AO1	2 min
3	“Explain how the writer presents …” (Text One)	10	AO2	15 min
4, 5	retrieve one, then two points from Text Two	1 + 2	AO1	2 min
6	“How does the writer present …” (Text Two)	10	AO2	15 min
7	compare ideas and perspectives in both texts	15	AO3	12 min
8	directed writing using ideas from both texts	30	AO1 10, AO4 12, AO5 8	60 min
9, 10 or 11	one of: argument, story, description (≈ 400 words)	30	AO4 20, AO5 10	60 min

What the texts and tasks have been

Paper	Theme: Text One / Text Two	Q8 form
Jan 19	reading: lecture / article	talk to peers
Jun 19	after-study activities: news article / article	letter to a newspaper
Jan 20	art: personal essay / teen opinion piece	letter to a friend
Nov 20	losing things: article / how-to article	talk to peers
Jun 21	travel: travel writing / blog	talk to peers
Nov 21	positive thinking: advice article / counter-argument article	talk to peers
Jan 22	hotels: novel (Hotel du Lac) / review	website contribution
Jun 22	grammar and technology: blog / article	website contribution
Jan 23	music: blog / article	letter to a friend
Jun 23	outdoors: article / travel book (A Walk in the Woods)	talk to peers
Nov 23	learning a skill: article / personal article	magazine article
Jun 24	environment: advice article / The Climate Book	letter to a friend
Nov 24	celebrations: article / blog	school website article
Jun 25	new places: novel (Salmon Fishing in the Yemen) / travel book	talk to peers
Nov 25	manners: digital etiquette guide / article on modern etiquette	letter to a friend
Jun 26	smartphones: opinion article / personal article (72 hours without a phone)	talk to peers

So: Text One and Text Two are usually non-fiction (articles, blogs, travel writing), with a novel extract about one paper in five. Q8 is a **talk** (7 times), a **letter** (5) or an **article / website piece** (4). The legacy 4EB0 paper (Jan 19) used retrieval and "own words" questions and is not the current format.

2 WHAT THE LEVELS REWARD

AO	What it means	Where
AO1	read and understand; select and interpret information, ideas and perspectives	Q1, 2, 4, 5, 8
AO2	analyse how writers use language and structure to achieve effects	Q3, Q6
AO3	explore links and connections between writers' ideas and perspectives, and how they are conveyed	Q7
AO4	communicate effectively and imaginatively, adapting form, tone and register to purpose and audience	Q8, Q9–11
AO5	write clearly: vocabulary, sentence structures, paragraphing, spelling, grammar, punctuation	Q8, Q9–11

Level	Q3/Q6 (AO2, /10)	Q7 (AO3, /15)	Q8 and Q9–11 (AO4)
1	basic identification; limited references	no comparison; description	basic; little awareness of purpose
2	some comment, incl. vocabulary; valid but undeveloped references	obvious comparisons	broadly appropriate
3	clear explanation of vocabulary and sentence structure; relevant references	a range of comparisons; explanation	communicates clearly; appropriate register
4	thorough exploration incl. other features; detailed references	a wide range; exploration across the texts	successful; secure purpose; effective register

Level	Q3/Q6 (AO2, /10)	Q7 (AO3, /15)	Q8 and Q9–11 (AO4)
5	**perceptive** analysis; **discriminating** references	**varied and comprehensive** range; analysis; balanced, discriminating references	**perceptive and subtle**; sophisticated form, tone and register

WHAT THE TOP LEVEL WORDS MEAN IN PRACTICE

Perceptive: you notice why the writer chose this word, not just what it means, and link it to the writer's purpose and the reader's response.

Discriminating references: short, precise quotations (one to five words), chosen because they carry the effect you are discussing. Long quotations are not discriminating.

Language and structure: Level 3 requires sentence structure as well as vocabulary; Levels 4–5 add "other language features" and structure across the whole text (openings, endings, shifts, contrasts).

3 TWENTY RULES FROM THE MARK SCHEMES

1. **Q1, 2, 4, 5 give one mark per valid point,** taken only from the line range or section named. A point from outside the lines scores nothing.
2. **Give exactly the number asked for.** One clear point per line; a list of guesses gains nothing extra.
3. **Short answers can quote or paraphrase:** "(breathtaking) landscapes", "towering cliffs" were all credited. Brackets in the mark scheme show words that are optional.
4. **Q3 and Q6 are AO2 only:** marks are for how the writer writes, not for retelling what happens.
5. **Comment on vocabulary and sentence structure** to reach Level 3; add other features and structure for Levels 4–5.
6. **Every technique needs an effect on the reader:** naming "simile" without saying what it suggests stays in Level 1–2.
7. **References must be brief and embedded:** the question says "including brief quotations".
8. **Cover the whole passage,** beginning, middle and end; the indicative content always ends with comments on the final lines.
9. **Q7: one text only caps the answer at Level 2 (6 marks).** Both texts, balanced, are required for Level 5.
10. **Q7 rewards comparison of ideas and perspectives and how they are conveyed:** theme, language and structure, plus genre, viewpoint and purpose.
11. **Q8: address all three bullet points.** The AO1 mark (10) is for selecting and interpreting the bullets.
12. **Q8: use ideas from both texts,** reworked into your own form; the mark scheme also credits wider ideas.
13. **Q8: adopt the register of the form named** ("a suitable register for a talk to peers / a letter to a newspaper / a letter to a friend should be adopted").
14. **Q8 and Section C: do not copy long stretches** of the source texts; Section C says "Do not re-tell events from Text One or Text Two".
15. **Section C argument:** "no audience is specified, so the examiner is the audience". You may agree, disagree, or weigh both sides.
16. **Section C story:** rewarded for "a sense of drama, vivid description, excitement or suspense". The title may appear only at the end.
17. **Section C description:** rewarded for "powers to evoke a sense of place and atmosphere", using effective vocabulary. Keep plot to a minimum.
18. **AO4 Level 5 = perceptive and subtle, sharply focused on purpose and reader,** with sophisticated control of form, tone and register.
19. **AO5 Level 5 = extensive vocabulary used strategically,** accurate punctuation for emphasis, and sentence structures chosen for particular effects.

20. **Plans are not marked** unless there is no other response: plan briefly, then write.

4 SHORT-ANSWER QUESTIONS (Q1, 2, 4, 5)

- Underline the line range or section heading, then read only those lines.
- Answer in a short phrase or sentence. Quote the key words if paraphrasing risks changing the meaning.
- "Identify / State / Give / Name" all mean the same: one fact, not an explanation.
- For Q5 (two marks), choose two clearly different points; two versions of the same idea score one mark.
- Typical prompts: "one reason", "one of the problems", "one piece of advice", "two unpleasant experiences", "two points the writer makes".
- Spend no more than about three minutes on all four: they carry 5 marks out of 100.

5 LANGUAGE ANALYSIS (Q3, Q6) AND COMPARISON (Q7)

METHOD FOR Q3 AND Q6 (10 MARKS, 15 MINUTES)

1. Read the question focus (e.g. "his experiences of travelling", "her advice", "her enthusiasm"). Every paragraph must return to it.

2. Track the passage in order, picking 6–8 short references from the opening, middle and ending.

3. For each: what the writer does (technique or word choice) → the brief quotation → what it suggests → the effect on the reader → how it serves the writer's purpose.

4. Include structure: how the text opens, shifts tone, uses contrast, and ends.

Feature	Effects the mark schemes credit
word choice (adjectives, verbs, adverbs)	"breathtaking" shows how amazed he is; "suddenly" conveys shock; harsh verbs "plunged", "crawling" show difficulty
imagery: simile, metaphor, personification	"slashed as if with a giant knife" is dramatic; "hills rolled and billowed" suggests gentleness
lists and tricolon	show range or variety; "a din of shouting voices, a riot of colour, unimaginable smells"
contrast	desert vs crowded towns shows the country's "startling contrasts"; problem vs solution builds hope
direct address, pronouns "you/we"	involves and includes the reader; reassures ("you can")
questions and imperatives	make the reader think; give clear, confident advice
statistics, research, expert opinion	shock the reader; add authority and credibility
anecdote, first person	personal, relatable, authentic; builds trust
humour, informal or colloquial register	engages a young audience; makes advice approachable
short sentences, repetition	emphasis; a final short sentence gives a memorable conclusion ("It is a magical place")
headings and sub-headings	organise advice into clear, easy-to-follow sections
semantic field	"spears of shimmery light", "escalators to heaven", "celestial music" create an other-worldly mood

MODEL PARAGRAPH · Q3 JUN 25 (TEXT ONE, SALMON FISHING IN THE YEMEN)

The narrator presents Yemen as overwhelming from the start. The adjective "breathtaking" shows the landscape has a physical effect on him, and the violent simile of wadis "slashed as if with a giant knife" suggests a land shaped by enormous force. He then sets the empty desert against the towns, where the tricolon "a din of shouting voices, a riot of colour, unimaginable smells" floods every sense at once. The contrast makes the reader feel the country's variety as he does: silence and space, then noise and crowds. By the end, the short sentence "It is a magical place" gives his final verdict a quiet certainty after so much description.

Why it scores highly: short embedded references; each one is analysed for meaning, effect on the reader and the writer's purpose; structure (contrast, the ending) is discussed, not only vocabulary.

Q7: comparing the two texts (15 marks, 12 minutes)

METHOD

Plan four to six comparison points before writing. Use the mark scheme's typical axes: genre and form (novel vs travel book, blog vs article); viewpoint (first-person, personal vs advisory); purpose (inform, persuade, entertain); ideas and attitude (positive vs critical); language (imagery, humour, statistics); structure (headings, chronology, how each ends).

Write integrated paragraphs: one idea, both texts, a brief quotation from each, and a comparative connective (whereas, similarly, in contrast, both).

Balance matters: Level 5 needs references "balanced across both texts".

MODEL COMPARISON PARAGRAPH · JUN 25

Both writers are impressed by what they see, but they convey it differently. Text One is a fictional narrative that moves between several journeys by car, piling up descriptions such as "towering cliffs" and "sculpted sand" to show the scale of the country. Text Two is a first-person travel account of a single walk, and Bryson mixes wonder ("beautiful beyond words") with comic suffering ("sweatily perplexed"). Whereas the narrator of Text One mostly observes, Bryson makes himself part of the scene, so the reader experiences both the view and the discomfort of reaching it.

- Do not write about Text One, then Text Two, then add one sentence of comparison: that is "obvious comparisons" (Level 2).
- Comment on ideas and perspectives as well as techniques: what each writer thinks, and why.

6 SECTION B: DIRECTED WRITING (Q8)

HOW THE 30 MARKS SPLIT

AO1 (10): selection and interpretation of ideas from both texts for all three bullets. Level 5: "a wide range of relevant points … perceptive references to information and ideas".

AO4 (12): form, tone and register for the stated audience. **AO5 (8):** accuracy and variety.

Form	Conventions to show	Register
talk to peers	greeting the audience, direct address, rhetorical questions, signposting ("First, …"), a memorable close ("Thank you for listening")	lively, inclusive, semi-formal
letter to a friend	"Dear …", personal opening, shared memories, advice, sign-off ("Best wishes")	warm, informal but accurate
letter to a newspaper	"Dear Editor", clear position in the first paragraph, evidence, call to action, "Yours faithfully"	formal, persuasive
article / website piece	headline, optional sub-headings, engaging opening, direct address, conclusion	matched to the readers (young adults, students, travellers)

METHOD (60 MINUTES)

10 minutes: list the three bullets as headings; under each, note three or four ideas from Text One and Text Two, then add one or two of your own.

45 minutes: write 5–7 paragraphs, roughly one or two per bullet, in the form required. Rework the source ideas in your own words and apply them to your audience.

5 minutes: check spelling, punctuation and paragraphing.

MODEL OPENING · TALK TO PEERS (JUN 25)

"Good morning, everyone. Picture the last time something truly surprised you. If you have to think hard, it is time to go somewhere new. Today I want to tell you what you might see, what you will love, and what might go wrong, because even a wrong turning can become the best story you bring home."

This signposts all three bullets, addresses the audience directly, and sets a confident, friendly register.

- Missing a bullet point lowers the AO1 level, however good the writing.
- Copying sentences from the texts is not interpretation; transform them (e.g. Bryson's blisters become advice about proper footwear).
- Keep the form consistent from the first line to the last: no letter conventions in a talk.

7 SECTION C: ARGUMENT, STORY, DESCRIPTION

Paper	Q9 argument	Q10 story title	Q11 description
Jan 19	it is better to live life than read about it	Friendship	an experience that made a positive difference
Jun 19	you have to work hard to get what you want	The Prize	—
Jan 20	everyone should study art at school	The Opportunity	a picture that made an impression
Nov 20	it is important to plan for the future	Just in Time	a helpful person and the help given
Jun 21	we only regret the chances we do not take	Doing the Right Thing	your favourite form of transport
Nov 21	always look on the bright side	The Choice	a place that makes you happy
Jan 22	travel broadens the mind	The Invitation	a time you stayed away from home
Jan 23	challenges make life interesting	The Turning Point	an event that featured music
Jun 23	fresh air and exercise are the keys to happiness	A Difficult Decision	your favourite walk
Nov 23	we are never too old to try something new	The Short Cut	a place that inspires you
Jun 24	working in a group is better than alone	The Future	the untidiest place you know
Nov 24	the best things in life are free	The Reunion	somewhere very busy
Jun 25	new opportunities present new challenges	The First Impression	a beautiful place
Nov 25	people are not always kind to each other	The Missed Message	your favourite possession
Jun 26	freedom and choice, as long as it harms no one	Lost and found	the view from your window

Q9 ARGUMENT OR DISCUSSION (APPROX. 400 WORDS)

Decide your line in the first sentence: agree, disagree, or "to some extent". Write 4–5 paragraphs: a hooking introduction with your view; two or three developed reasons with examples (personal, social, global); a counter-argument that you answer; a decisive conclusion that echoes the opening.

Use discourse markers (admittedly, however, consequently), rhetorical questions sparingly, and varied evidence. The examiner is the audience: write in a confident, formal register.

Q10 STORY

Plan a simple arc: a vivid opening in the middle of action, one complication, a turning point, a resolution that links to the title. Use a small cast and a short time span: 400 words cannot hold a whole life.

Show, do not tell: dialogue, sensory detail, and varied sentence lengths for pace and suspense. The title may be revealed only at the end, which can be an effective twist.

Q11 DESCRIPTION

Describe, do not narrate: organise by place or by time (dawn to dusk, entrance to centre), and use the senses, precise nouns and verbs, and a controlled mood. One extended image or a returning motif gives cohesion.

End by returning to the opening image changed, to show deliberate structure (an AO5 Level 5 feature).

8 AO5: TECHNICAL ACCURACY

Level 5 (AO5) asks for	How to show it
extensive vocabulary used strategically	precise, not showy: "trudged", "luminous", "relentless"; avoid repeated "very", "nice", "good"
accurate punctuation for emphasis and precision	colons for explanation, semicolons to balance ideas, dashes for asides, a question or exclamation used once for impact
a range of sentence structures for particular effects	a one-word or short sentence after a long one; fronted adverbials; a list for accumulation
coherence and cohesion	paragraphs with clear topic sentences; linking words; an ending that echoes the opening

- The errors that keep scripts at Level 3: comma splices, missing apostrophes (it's/its), their/there/they're, inconsistent tense in stories, and no paragraphs.
- Write with dark, clear handwriting and leave two minutes per writing task to proofread.

9 TIMING PLAN AND FINAL CHECKLIST

Section	Time	Split
A Reading	60 min	read Text One (7) · Q1–2 (2) · Q3 (15) · read Text Two (7) · Q4–5 (2) · Q6 (15) · Q7 (12)
B Directed writing	60 min	plan 10 · write 45 · check 5
C Writing	60 min	choose and plan 10 · write about 400 words in 40 · check 10

1. Q1, 2, 4, 5: only the lines named; one point per mark.
2. Q3, Q6: technique + brief quotation + effect on reader + writer's purpose; cover the whole text; include sentence structure and structure.
3. Q7: both texts in every paragraph, balanced references, ideas and perspectives as well as techniques.
4. Q8: all three bullets; ideas from both texts, transformed; the form and register named in the task.

5. Section C: plan before writing; argument with a clear stance; story with drama and a resolution; description with atmosphere, not plot.
6. Every writing answer: varied sentences, ambitious but accurate vocabulary, deliberate punctuation, paragraphs.
7. Leave the last five minutes of each section to proofread.